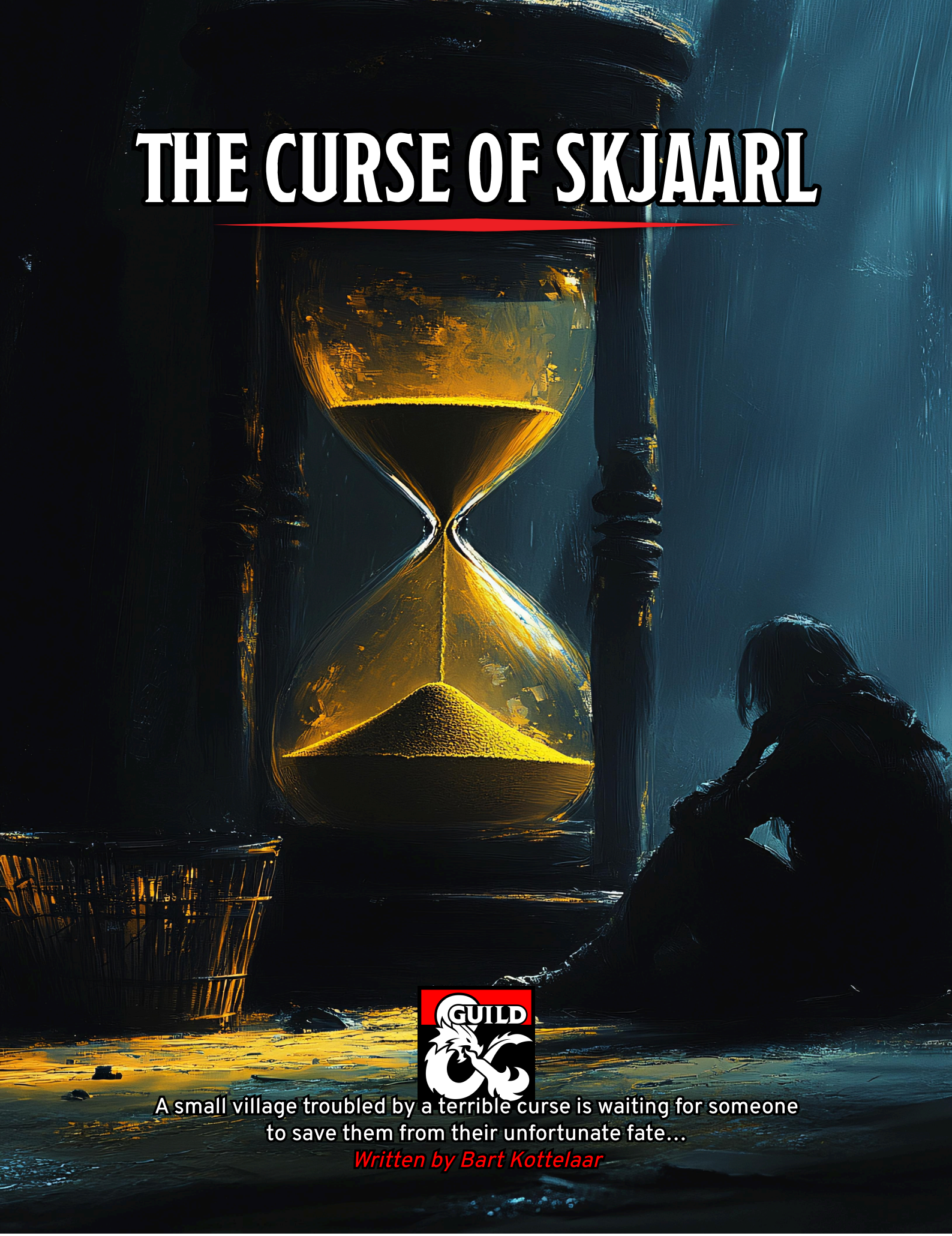
THE CURSE OF SKJAARL



A small village troubled by a terrible curse is waiting for someone to save them from their unfortunate fate...

Written by Bart Kottelaar

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The Curse of Skjaarl

A MYSTERIOUS CURSE HAS TRAPPED THE VILLAGERS of the tiny village of Skjaarl, with no hope of escape. It is up to a band of daring adventurers to free the townsfolk from their predicament, otherwise they might end up trapped there themselves...

Adventure Summary

Those who live in the village of Skjaarl, or dare venture there, become trapped by an evil curse that has taken hold there no more than a few weeks prior. Once within half a mile of the village it is impossible to leave the area, immediately ending back up on one of the roads leading into the village, no matter where or how far they may attempt to travel. It is up to the adventurers to break the curse and allow everyone to freely leave the village and its surrounding area once more.

Once inside the village the adventurers will face a small band of *Mephits* (small imp-like creatures)) that blame the villagers and have been regularly attacking the townsfolk in an attempt to end the curse that has also been plaguing them. After dealing with the attack the mayor will explain the curse and the adventurers too are now trapped. They must investigate the townsfolk and surroundings of the village to find the source of the curse, as well as the culprit(s) responsible.

After a thorough investigation the adventurers will be able to determine that the curse has been cast by Melinda Bellemund, one of the villagers. She is a woman scorned and cast the curse to punish her husband and the woman with whom he was cheating. Upon either confronting or attacking her she will fight back to try and kill either her husband, the other woman, or the adventurers themselves if they get in the way.

After she has been defeated, either by killing, exiling, or otherwise incapacitating her the adventurers will be rewarded for their help, and will also be able to continue their travels, no longer constrained by the bindings of the curse.

Introduction

The village of Skjaarl is located somewhere deep in a dark and large forest, in a relatively hard to reach place, only visited by travelers who know it's there, or by those who become hopelessly lost. Its somewhat obscured location comes from a desire of the townspeople to be free of the turmoil of the big cities, and to live a calm life in which they provide for themselves, free of the constraints of urban living. The village has existed for a long time, and has never had more than twenty-five inhabitants at once, in current day dwindling to a mere ten.

The village has a small inn mostly used as a gathering place for the locals after a day of hard work, but also functioning as a place of refuge for travelers passing by. There is no general store in the village, as the community is too small to sustain such a business. The various townspeople do however have small shops outside their homes where they sell some basic foodstuffs, artworks, and tools to both their neighbors and visitors. These shops are nothing more than a little stall with a small amount of merchandise and a wooden box in which people can drop money to pay for their purchases.

While the village is usually an oasis of peace, recently it has suffered some serious problems, troubling both locals and visitors alike. The last few weeks any who have attempted to leave the village have found that they will start feeling dizzy and slowly blackout after half a mile or so, after which they suddenly find themselves back on one of the two roads leading into the village as if they were just arriving. Since the locals have little to no knowledge of magic, they are unsure how to deal with this seemingly magical problem, and they have been trapped in their village for weeks. Travelers and visitors simply passing through have found themselves in the same predicament, and are forced to reside in the local inn, unable to leave the village. As if these problems were not bad enough, a roaming group of *Mephits* got stuck in the curse as well, and is blaming the townsfolk. They've periodically been attacking the townspeople since they believe them to be responsible, but so far this has not had much effect. They have been present near the village since the start of the curse, fueling speculation amongst the locals that the *Mephits* have something to do with the current troubles.

Running the adventure

The Curse of Skjaarl is an adventure for three to four adventurers of 2nd level. At the end of the adventure they would level up to 3rd level using the milestone experience system, should you want to use the same characters for another future module. The various combat statistics of the monsters and people used in this adventure can all be found at the bottom of the module. The same goes for any magical items that may be found.

Adjusting difficulty

Each encounter is tailored toward a group of three to four adventurers of 2nd level with only limited experience and knowledge about D&D. Each encounter also offers two different difficulties (both easier and harder) to adjust the combat intensity to your liking.

Overview

While the village is pretty much the only setting in which this module will take place, the story can roughly be divided up into three parts:

- In part 1 the adventurers will enter the village and deal with an attack of *Mephits*.
- In part 2 the adventurers will learn about the curse from the local people and start their investigation.
- In part 3 the adventurers will locate the source of the curse and lift it by defeating the person(s) or creature(s) responsible.

Adventure hooks

The hook for your adventurers to solve this quest is relatively simple. The village of Skjaarl is in the middle of a big forest, and can easily be used as a short resting point for travelers going from one big city to another, or for those who have simply become lost. Once inside the village the adventurers will be stuck there themselves until they lift the curse, forcing them to participate in the module.

Should you so wish you can always come up with a more distinct reason why the adventurers are traveling from one place to another to match with an ongoing campaign, or fit a specific setting.

Part 1: Welcome to Skjaarl

The adventure begins with the adventurers traveling through the forest en route to a destination of their choice. During their journey through the forest you can have them interact with each other to introduce their characters, and explain their reasons for traveling. Once the introductions have been made and everyone is ready to begin the module, read the following text:

Your calm and peaceful journey through the woods is suddenly interrupted by the barely noticeable but distinct sounds of combat in the distance. Somewhat worried you exchange a glance with your fellow adventurers, before drawing your weapons and heading towards the noise. You pass a slight bend in the road and suddenly find yourselves on the outskirts of a very small village in a clearing in the woods. There can be no more than eight buildings here, most of them positioned in half a circle around a larger building which you immediately deduce must be the local inn. At the centre of the village is an old-fashioned water well behind which an older man, bloodied and bruised, is seeking refuge from multiple flying imp-like creatures. As you near the village the man sees you and waves his sword at you, calling out for help. He pays dearly for trying to draw your attention as one of the flying creatures manages to land a clean hit on the man's head, knocking him out cold. Now with the old man down the creatures turn around and charge at you!

Combat Encounter

The adventurers will face off against a number of *Mephits* (determined by the difficulty you choose). Once just one of the *Mephits* is brought to 0 hit points it will retain its consciousness but will flee away along with the other *Mephits*, leaving the adventurers alone with the unconscious older man.

Mephits come in various forms (Dust, Ice, Steam, and Magma). Feel free to determine at random what kind of *Mephits* are used (even multiple different ones). Take note that *Steam Mephits* are slightly weaker than the other types.

- Easy encounter: 2 *Mephits*.
- Average encounter: 3 *Mephits*. (Recommended.)
- Hard encounter: 4 *Mephits*.

The Village of Skjaarl

Once the fight has concluded, read the following passage:

As the last of the Mephits flies off with the motionless body of one of its kin in his hands, you suddenly hear a door fly open, and rapid footsteps. As you turn you see a large woman with long braids and a rather round face waving you inside. She yells at you to bring the unconscious man and after you've managed to pick him up and drag him to the inn, she quickly closes the door behind you.

The innkeeper is called Freya Wildeheart and she will welcome the adventurers in town, thank them for saving the village and the old man, and will offer them board and sustenance as a reward for their assistance. She will go on to explain the predicament the village faces, and explains the curse, pointing out that by entering the village the adventurers themselves have now also become trapped in the curse that has been plaguing the villagers. She shares this information with the adventurers while tending to the wounds of the old man, whom she identifies as Hagar Steelhammer, a retired adventurer who has been their main line of defense against the attacks of the *Mephits*. The imp-like pests have been attacking the villagers believing them to be responsible for the curse, and trapping them in the woods with no way of escape.

From this point on the adventurers are stuck in the village, and trying to leave the village will cause them to blackout after about half a mile, after which they will find themselves back on one of the two roads leading into the village.

Part 2: Investigating the curse

The village

The adventurers must investigate the village and its people to find the source of the curse.The village consists of seven buildings: the inn and six other buildings.

Should the adventurers attempt to leave the village without any direction they will simply end up back on one of the two roads leading into the village after about half a mile. Within the bounds of the curse there are two points of interest that can be found by either gaining directions from the townsfolk, or by successfully navigating the forest:

- Following Jacynda's advice they can go South and find the hut of a local witch (or a DC18 Survival check if they are looking for signs of habitation in the local area).
- If they follow Hagar's advice they can go North and find a small cave that serves as the home for the *Mephits* (or a DC17 Survival check if they're looking for the *Mephits*).

The map and various locations

In the map below the village is shown along with the locations that can be visited. Each location has a separate description and information about its inhabitants and function within the village as a whole. These descriptions can be found on the next pages and serve as your guideline for your adventurers traversing through the town. It is advised to read them beforehand, as to understand who the townsfolk are and how some of them are connected.

The statistics for each villager are simply those of a commoner, with the exception of Melinda Bellemund who is secretly a witch and uses the statblock of a *Green Hag* and Hagar Steelhammer who is a retired adventurer and uses the statblock of a *Bandit*. Both statblocks are detailed at the end of this module along with the other statblocks such as the *Mephits*.



The Black Egg Inn

The Black Egg Inn is a quaint and cute little inn that fits well into the atmosphere of the village. It has three floors in total. The ground floor consists of a small tavern with a bar, multiple tables, a hearth, some cozy decorations, a small kitchen and storage area, and living quarters for the innkeeper in the back. The first floor contains four rooms each with two beds, although there is enough space for people to place bedrolls next to the beds allowing four people to sleep in a single room. The second floor is also the attic, and consists of a singular room that serves as permanent living and working quarters to Freya Wildeheart, the mayor of the town.

The people that can regularly be found in the inn during the day are: Timotheus Kirk, Freya Wildeheart, Richard Clearrock, and Moonflower.

Timotheus Kirk is the owner of the inn and married to Freya Wildeheart. He is a man of large stature with a big gut, and an even bigger mustache. He is rather jolly, and seems to enjoy the taste of his own ale as much as his customers do, and can always be found either drinking or eating. When questioned about the curse he will admit that he knows very little about magic, and that he just wishes things would go back to normal. He is one of the few townsfolk who enjoys the presence of visitors due to the nature of his business as an innkeeper. If pressed about the curse he will admit that he believes the local druid, Jacynda, must know something about it, as she is the only local person familiar with magic. He urges you to not tell his wife about his suspicions, as Freya and Jacynda are good friends.

Freya Wildeheart is the mayor of the town and married to Timotheus Kirk. She is a physically frail woman with red hair and is skin over bone due to her worries about the town and the curse. Her eyes are however filled with fire and she's determined to help shepherd her people through these dark times. She's righteous and has a firm belief in justice, and asks the adventurers to offer aid in whichever way they can to help lift the curse.

When questioned about the curse she will reveal that she has no idea about the how or why. She will provide the adventurers with basic information about the various townspeople explaining that Hagar is an old adventurer, but has long since been retired; that there is a married couple called Melinda and Otho Dayfallow; that there is a single family, the Wray family; that there is a local druid with limited magical powers called Jacynda; that there is a lone woman called Sadani living in town; and that the surrounding wilds can be quite dangerous when traversed without knowing where to go.

If pressed about the curse, she will merely state that she does not belief Jacynda has anything to do with it, as she trusts the druidess with her very life. She admits however that there is another user of magic in the locality, and refers the adventurers to Jacynda for more information.

Moonflower is a traveling priestess who works for the temple of Eldath, goddess of peace. Her hair is long and black, often tied up in a knot on her head, and she has bright blue eyes. She was on her way from one town to another spreading the word of her goddess and doing good deeds when she got trapped in the village several days ago due to the curse. She states that on the one hand she feels like her goddess brought her here to help, but on the other hand feels rather helpless because she is not familiar with magic. Her deeds in other cities mostly consist of spending money to help the needy by buying them food or blankets, or providing housing in local temples.

When questioned about the curse she will express certainty that the curse has a distinctly evil origin, as she feels that the village is steeped in negative energy. What or who causes this is unknown to her however.

If pressed about the curse she will not be able to provide any more information.

Richard Clearrock is a traveling merchant with beady little eyes, a thin little mustache, and greasy hair. He mostly sells trinkets which he claims to be magical, but which are in fact mundane objects. If the adventurers talk to him he will explain that he too, like Moonflower, was traveling from city to city when he got trapped in the village last week, and has since been unable to leave. He will however try to make the most of the situation and attempt to sell the adventurers multiple rings he claims have magical properties (such as invisibility or invulnerability).

When questioned about the curse he will immediately blame Hagar Steelhammer, as the two of them had a run in during his initial arrival in town. Richard will claim that Hagar is somehow responsible for the curse so he could claim all the glory for lifting it later, thus reliving his glory days.

If pressed about the curse he will not be able to provide any more information.

Home of Hagar Steelhammer

Hagar Steelhammer is an old bald man with impressive muscles, and was badly hurt during the scuffle with the *Mephits* when the adventurers entered the village. Under the care of Freya Wildeheart his wounds are tended to, and he is quickly returned home to rest and recover. He is a gruff and direct man with a penchant for swearing, especially when his manliness is in question. He is not amused by his defeat at the hands of the *Mephits* earlier, and is more than willing, but not at all capable in his current state, to go out and fight them again to regain his honor.

When questioned about the curse he will immediately blame the *Mephits*, stating that they are universally

known as tricksters, something he learned from his days as an adventurer. In his eyes they are simply toying with the townsfolk and trying to provoke them. He will suggest the *Mephits* are likely hiding in one of the nearby grottos, due North of the village, providing the adventurers with clear enough instructions to likely be able to find the caves he mentioned.

If pressed about the curse he will reiterate his belief that the *Mephits* are solely responsible for all the problems the village is facing. Should the adventurers be able to defeat the *Mephits* he promises them his old Longsword (+1) from his adventuring days, but only if they bring proof by returning with the head of the *Mephit* leader.

When asked about Richard Clearrock he will voice disdain at the hearing of his name. He considered the merchant nothing more than a conman and tried to force him to leave when he arrived, but was prevented in doing so by the curse. Both men have since avoided each other as much as they could.

In front of his house is a small shop containing various basic weapons that can be bought such as swords, daggers, and bows for 50gp a piece.

Home of Jacynda the Druid

Jacynda Mossfall is the local druidess and usually makes potions and ointments for the other villagers to deal with injuries and illnesses. When talking with her she offers them a standard *Potion of Healing* (2d4+2 hit points) as a reward for helping the village against the attack of the *Mephits*. She goes on to explain that she does not believe the *Mephits* are to blame, but that they too are stuck in the curse as the villagers are, and are simply trying to deal with their predicament. Because she regularly makes a concoction for both Bernard Wray and Sadani (both inhabitants of the village, see below for more information) to help them with their hunting in the woods, her house has a rather musky smell to it.

When questioned about the curse she explains that she is not well-versed in this kind of magic, and her strength lies in potions and nature. She admits that she may know someone that might be able to shed more light on the current situation. Her sister, Agnes Mossfall, is a witch and lives in a small shack not too far from the village. Out of fear for prosecution, as she was nearly executed for witchery in the big city several decades ago, she decided to isolate herself completely. She now lives a calm and peaceful life nearby, separated from the village, unbeknownst to them. Jacynda asks the adventurers not to reveal her existence to the rest of the villagers as she fears they will blame her for all the problems that the villagers are facing.

If pressed about the curse Jacynda admits that she fears her sister has something to do with it, although in her heart she feels that Agnes is innocent.

In front of her house is a little shop with potions, where adventurers can buy 1d4 *potions of healing* for 50gp a piece.

Home of Melinda and Otho Bellemund

Melinda and Otho Bellemund are a married couple who have lived in the village for most of their lives. Melinda has long brown hair and bright green eyes, while Otho has the stature of a woodsman and a big rough beard. Otho serves as a handyman for the village and takes care of most repairs, works the fields when needed, builds new houses or barns, and manages any animals. Melinda does something similar: she weaves baskets and the like, knits, makes candles, artisan products, does woodworking, and has a little garden of herbs. Otho is engaged in an extramarital affaire with Sadani, and they meet regularly at night in the local abandoned shack (both Otho and Sadani have keys to the lock). When approaching Otho he carries a rather musky smell, which is the same smell that comes from the concoction made by Jacynda for the hunters Bernard and Sadani. This smell has transferred onto Otho due to his intimacy with Sadani. Melinda is well aware of this affaire and is in fact the witch that has cursed the village to punish them all, but mostly Sadani who has fallen into a deep depression since the curse took effect. Otho is unaware of this fact. Inside their home is a small trapdoor leading into the basement through which Otho does not fit, which means only Melinda goes down there. In the basement is a second trapdoor, hidden beneath some crates and bags, which leads to a ladder and subsequent tunnel leading into the cave beneath the abandoned shack where the curse totem is located.

When questioned about the curse the pair will state that they are unsure who or what could have caused it. During the conversation there will however be clear tension in the air between them, and Melinda will be snappy and rude to Otho. Their best guess will be to try and track down the *Mephits* that have been terrorizing the village.

If pressed about the curse Melinda will get angry and ask why the adventurers are wasting their time here when they could be out trying to lift the curse.

When confronted about being a witch, or when her totem is destroyed, Melinda will get angry and try and kill Otho and Sadani outright. If the adventurers intervene she will target them instead. See Part 3 for more information about this potential encounter.

In front of their house is a small shop containing small trinkets such as wood carvings, candles, and artisan products for 5gp each.

Abandoned Shack

The abandoned shack is in a state of serious disrepair and yet is boarded up tightly. When asking around town about the shack people will state that in the past it was used by the townsfolk to store tools and foodstuffs, but that strange things started happening to it in recent years leading them to believe that it became haunted. Since it has been haunted for such a long time the townsfolk don't see a connection between the shack and the curse. When pressed about what specifically makes it haunted they will explain that things started to move around, there were strange shadows and sounds, and people would often feel a strange and evil presence watching them. These rumors were in fact created by Otho Bellemund and Sadani, who wanted a nearby and easy to reach location to engage in their extramarital affaire.

The shack itself is boarded up and cannot be easily entered. The front door is locked up with a padlock that requires a key that is in possession of Freya Wildeheart, the mayor of the town (but unbeknownst to most, copies exist in the hands of Otho Bellemund and Sadani). Trying to pick the lock requires a DC16 Lockpicking check. Trying to force the door down instead, or trying to pry open the boards in front of the windows requires a DC17 Athletics check.

Inside the shack the adventurers will find the remains of many rusty and long unused tools, cobwebs, layers upon layers of dust, barrels filled with rotten food, and beneath it all a trapdoor leading to what is most likely a subterranean storage area. When they try to open the trapdoor they will find that it does not move in the slightest, and cannot be picked, nor forced open. The trapdoor is being held in place with invisible magical chains that can only be seen with Detect Magic or See Invisibility. The chains are of too high a level to simply dispel with any ordinary spell and can only be removed by uttering a special codeword (in this case: TRAITOR), or by using the magical scroll that can be provided by Agnes Mossfall. When asking around town about the trapdoor everyone will mention that it has been closed for ages, and no one knows how to open it. If the adventurers discuss the magical chains the villagers will refer them to Jacynda Mossfall, who will in turn refer them to her sister Agnes Mossfall.

Beneath the trapdoor is a hallway that leads down into a small cave that was indeed once used for storage, but is now clearly being used to house the totem for the curse. In the center of the cave is a bear skull mounted on top of a spear, with some of its rotting flesh and sinews still attached, surrounded by a circle of black candles.

If the party investigates the cave more thoroughly (DC14 Investigation check) they will find a hidden passage that leads into a tunnel. This tunnel leads to a ladder up another trapdoor, which ends up in the house of Otho and Melinda Bellemund.

Home of the Wray Family

The Wray family consists of Bernard Wray, his wife Jennifer Wray, and their ten year old son Alexander Wray. Bernard is a long wiry man who is used to working the fields and scouring the woods; Jennifer has a rather round face and a full figure; and their son has short brown hair and is a whirlwind of energy. They're a simple average family and understand little of the curse and current events and just hope for someone to save them from their predicament. They work as farmers and gatherers for the village, collecting a lot of the food that the village relies on. Bernard occasionally travels alongside Sadani to hunt for food in the local woods. To hide their scent from prey they douse themselves in a special concoction from Jacynda that has a very musky smell. When approaching Bernard or entering the home this smell becomes apparent.

When questioned about the curse they will mention that they know nothing about magic and that they have no idea who or what is causing it. They will however reveal that they regularly see a shadowy figure near the local abandoned shack late at night. Bernard Wray will also state that not too long ago he saw Melinda Bellemund walking around in the woods, something she has specifically stated she hates, which is why he remembered.

If the adventurers question Alexander he will state that he knows nothing about the curse, but that he does have secrets to keep. He is aware of the existence of Agnes Mossfall, the local witch living in the woods, and will be able to point the adventurers in the right direction. He will also divulge that he has often seen Otho Bellemund leave his house late at night and sneak to the house of Sadani.

In front of their house is a small shop that contains agricultural produce and berries that can be bought for 5gp each.

Home of Sadani

Sadani is somewhat of a relative outsider to the village. She's short of stature, has a rather athletic build, and short black hair. She arrived in the village several years ago as a traveling hunter, fell in love with the ambience of the locale, and decided to stay. She has since been one of the hunters for the village, occasionally accompanied by Bernard Wray. For the hunting process she uses a concoction made by Jacynda Mossfall which has a rather musky smell that becomes apparent when in her vicinity or in her home. She has quite a temperament and is hot headed, easily provoked, but also passionate and driven. Unbeknownst to most she is engaged in a extramarital affair with Otho Bellemund. They regularly meet up at night in the local abandoned

shack of which both Otho and Sadani have the key (to the front door, not to the trapdoor leading down).

When questioned about the curse she will cast blame on Melinda, stating that they've never gotten along and that she doesn't like her at all, and that there's something fishy about her. She is however unable to clarify why exactly there is bad blood between the two of them (she will not easily admit to engaging in an extramarital affaire with Otho).

If pressed about the curse she will admit that the curse has made her intensely depressed as her love for hunting in the wilds has been stifled by the limited area of the curse. Should the curse last much longer she feels that the feeling of being trapped might become too much to bear.

In front of her house is a small shop that sells animal skins and teeth for 10gp each.

The surrounding wilds

The surrounding wilds can only be explored to a limited degree. After travelling for half a mile in one direction the players will pass out and find themselves on one of the two roads leading into Skjaarl.

Witch's hut of Agnes Mossfall

Agnes Mossfall is a frail old woman with a crooked back and covered in warts, a classic representation of what a witch might look like. Because of her appearance and her aptitude for magic she was the victim of a witch hunt in a large and nearby city, but managed to flee and find refuge in the woods near her sister Jacynda. The two have remained in limited contact, as to not accidentally reveal the existence and presence of Agnes to the rest of the villagers. Her little shack is skillfully hidden between the shrubberies and is usually further obscured with a simple illusion spell when any of the villagers comes too close. She spends her time studying simple spells from her books, or brewing potions from the local ingredients. Inside her shack is a simple potion of healing, a potion of night vision, as well as a spell scroll of Open Magical Lock (which is intended to be used on the trapdoor in the abandoned shack in Skjaarl).

When asked about the curse she will reveal that the curse was cast by a quite powerful spellcaster, much more powerful than herself, and that its epicenter is clearly inside the village. She explains that this kind of spell requires a totem to maintain it, most likely an animal skull of sorts, that serves as a focus. It must be surrounded by candles at all times to keep the spell fueled. Extinguishing the candles will break the spell, but destroying the skull with prevent it from being recast. She offers the adventurers the magical scroll, as well as both potions to help them in their quest.

If pressed about the curse she will admit that the culprit is likely a scorned woman, which is something she can sense in the magic that hangs in the air.

The Mephit cave

The cave system can be found with a successful DC17 Survival check, or by learning of its location from Hagar Steelhammer. This cave is rather small and is just big enough to house (2d4+1) *Mephits* that have sought refuge here. The *Mephits* were servants of a wizard but were freed from his service when he died in his sleep. With the wizard dead, and his tower now unprotected, more and more adventurers came by to ransack the place. Before any adventurers dared attempt to loot the tower proper the *Mephits* decided to take some valuables and leave the tower in search of a new home.

When the adventurers approach the caves the *Mephits* will warn them to stay away or they will use force, and that the villagers must break the curse if they wish the attacks to stop. Despite their hostile attitude they are more than willing to talk if the adventurers do nothing to provoke them.

The adventurers must make a choice to try and either talk to the *Mephits* or fight with them (which can still lead to combat if the adventurers provoke them).

The Mephits will explain that they have nothing to do with the curse, and that their attacks on the village are only because they are certain that's the epicenter of the curse. Their time as servants for a wizard has given them a keen understanding of magic, and they are convinced that one of the villagers is responsible, using what they call a 'totem' of sorts to fuel the curse. This totem is a physical object used in a magical ritual to create the spell that is trapping everyone inside the village and surroundings.

Combat Encounter

If the adventurers decide to fight they will face off against a number and type of *Mephits* of your choice.

- Easy encounter: 2 *Mephits*.
- Average encounter: 3 *Mephits*. (Recommended.)
- Hard encounter: 4 *Mephits*.

The *Mephits* drop 3d10gp and a ring that grants +1AC.

Part 3: Dealing with the Witch

Once the adventurers have figured out who the culprit is (Melinda Bellemund) they can choose in which way to confront and defeat her. Her totem is placed in the caves beneath the abandoned shack and can be reached either through her own house or through the shack. In order to conclude the quest the adventurers must destroy the totem at the very least, while they may choose how to deal with Melinda Bellemund. Should they only destroy the totem but not deal with the witch she will go on a rampage, attempting to kill both Otho and Sadani. Without intervention from the adventurers she will succeed in doing so and leave the village afterward to start life anew somewhere else.

Should the players choose to confront her she will still attempt to kill both Sadani and Otho using her magical abilities. As a witch she is capable of becoming invisble and moving about unseen, and she can create an illusory appearance attempting to imitate one of the adventurers or villagers. She will use subtrifuge and deception to try and evade capture and accomplish her goal. If she is however forced into a direct fight she will not shy away from it and will attack those whom she deems the biggest danger. Her anger and stubbornness will prevent her from running away or surrendering willingly.

Should any inexperienced adventurers be overwhelmed by the fight, and should Melinda Bellemund prove victorious, she will cast them aside without actually killing them, focusing her efforts on killing Otho and Sadani, giving the adventurers a chance to recover.

Combat Encounter

The adventurers will face off against Melinda who has the stats of a *Green Hag*.

- Easy encounter: *Green Hag* (minus 20 maximum hit points).
- Average encounter: *Green Hag*.
- Hard encounter: *Green Hag* and a summoned *Shadow*.

Conclusion

The outcomes for either killing or capturing her aren't much different. Should Melinda Bellemund be killed the mayor and townsfolk will commend the adventurers for their bravery and reward them accordingly (see the rewards section).

If she is instead captured the townsfolk will reward them in the same manner, but will hold a short public trial declaring her guilty of the charges, and to be either imprisoned or otherwise dealt with, as advised by the adventurers who helped bring her to justice.

As a final thank you mayor Freya Wildeheart will state that the village will, in time, erect statues of them to remember the heroes that saved Skjaarl.

Rewards

As a reward for saving the village of Skjaarl by breaking the curse and bringing the witch to justice the adventurers will receive the following:

- 3d100 gold coins.
- 1 Longsword (+1).
- 2 healing potions (2d4+2).

Statblocks

Dust Mephit

Small Elemental, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 12
Hit Points 17 (5d6)
Speed 30 ft., fly 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
5 (-3)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	9 (-1)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills Perception +2, Stealth +4
Damage vulnerabilities Fire
Damage immunities Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 12
Languages Auran, Terran
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP) **Proficiency Bonus** +2

Traits

Death Burst. When the mephit dies, it explodes in a burst of dust. Each creature within 5 feet of it must then succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw or be blinded for 1 minute. A blinded creature can repeat the saving throw on each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success.

Innate Spellcasting (1/Day). The mephit can innately cast *sleep*, requiring no material components. Its innate spellcasting ability is Charisma.

Actions

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 4 (1d4 + 2) slashing damage.

Blinding Breath (Recharge 6). The mephit exhales a 15-foot cone of blinding dust. Each creature in that area must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or be blinded for 1 minute. A creature can repeat the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself on a success.

Ice Mephit

Small Elemental, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 11
Hit Points 21 (6d6)
Speed 30 ft., fly 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
7 (-2)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)	9 (-1)	11 (+0)	12 (+1)

Skills Perception +2, Stealth +3
Damage vulnerabilities Bludgeoning, Fire
Damage immunities Cold, Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 12
Languages Aquan, Auran
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP) **Proficiency Bonus** +2

Traits

Death Burst. When the mephit dies, it explodes in a burst of jagged ice. Each creature within 5 feet of it must then succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw, taking 4 (1d8) slashing damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

False Appearance. While the mephit remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from an ordinary shard of ice.

Innate Spellcasting (1/Day). The mephit can innately cast *fog cloud*, requiring no material components. Its innate spellcasting ability is Charisma.

Actions

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 3 (1d4 + 1) slashing damage plus 2 (1d4) cold damage.

Frost Breath (Recharge 6). The mephit exhales a 15-foot cone of cold air. Each creature in that area must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw, taking 5 (2d4) cold damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Magma Mephit

Small Elemental, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 11
Hit Points 22 (5d6+5)
Speed 30 ft., fly 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	7 (-2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills Stealth +3
Damage vulnerabilities Cold
Damage immunities Fire, Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 10
Languages Ignan, Terran
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP) **Proficiency Bonus** +2

Traits

Death Burst. When the mephit dies, it explodes in a burst of lava. Each creature within 5 feet of it must then succeed on a DC 11 Dexterity saving throw, taking 7 (2d6) fire damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

False Appearance. While the mephit remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from an ordinary mound of lava.

Innate Spellcasting (1/Day). The mephit can innately cast *heat metal* (spell save DC 10), requiring no material components. Its innate spellcasting ability is Charisma.

Actions

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 3 (1d4 + 1) slashing damage plus 2 (1d4) fire damage.

Fire Breath (Recharge 6). The mephit exhales a 15-foot cone of fire. Each creature in that area must succeed on a DC 11 Dexterity saving throw, taking 7 (2d6) fire damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Steam Mephit

Small Elemental, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 10
Hit Points 21 (6d6)
Speed 30 ft., fly 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
5 (-3)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)

Damage immunities Fire, Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 10
Languages Aquan, Ignan
Challenge 1/4 (50 XP) **Proficiency Bonus** +2

Traits

Death Burst. When the mephit dies, it explodes in a burst of steam. Each creature within 5 feet of the mephit must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw, or take 4 (1d8) fire damage.

Innate Spellcasting (1/Day). The mephit can innately cast *blur*, requiring no material components. Its innate spellcasting ability is Charisma.

Actions

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 2 (1d4) slashing damage plus 2 (1d4) fire damage.

Steam Breath (Recharge 6). The mephit exhales a 15-foot cone of scalding steam. Each creature in that area must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw, taking 4 (1d8) fire damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Melinda Bellemund (Green Hag statblock, adjusted)

Medium Humanoid, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 17
Hit Points 82 (11d8+33)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)

Skills Arcana +3, Deception +4, Perception +4, Stealth +3
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 14
Languages Common, Draconic, Sylvan
Challenge 3 (700 XP) **Proficiency Bonus** +2

Traits

Amphibious. Melinda Bellemund can breathe air and water.

Innate Spellcasting (1/Day). Melinda Bellemund's innate spellcasting ability is Charisma (spell save DC 12). She can innately cast the following spells, requiring no material components:

At will: dancing lights, minor illusion, vicious mockery.

Mimicry. Melinda Bellemund can mimic animal sounds and humanoid voices. A creature that hears the sounds can tell they are imitations with a successful DC 14 Wisdom (Insight) check.

Actions

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 13 (2d8+4) slashing damage.

Illusory Apperance. Melinda Bellemund covers herself and anything she is wearing or carrying with a magical illusion that makes her look like another creature of her general size and humanoid shape. The illusion ends if she takes a bonus action to end it or if she dies.

The changes wrought by this effect fail to hold up to physical inspection. For example, Melinda Bellemund could appear to have smooth skin, but someone touching her would feel her rough flesh. Otherwise, a creature must take an action to visually inspect the illusion and succeed on a DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation) check to discern that she is disguised.

Invisible Passage. Melinda Bellemund turns invisible until she attacks or casts a spell, or until her concentration ends (as if concentrating on a spell). While invisible, she leaves no physical evidence of her passage, so she can be tracked only by magic. Any equipment she wears or carries is invisible with her.

Hagar Steelhammer (Bandit statblock, adjusted)

Small Elemental, Neutral Evil

Armor Class 12
Hit Points 11 (2d8+2)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Senses Passive Perception 10
Languages Any one language (usually Common)
Challenge 1/8 (25 XP) **Proficiency Bonus** +2

Actions

Scimitar. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 4 (1d6+1) slashing damage.

Light Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, range 80 ft./320 ft., one target. *Hit* 5 (1d8+1) piercing damage.

Commoner

Medium Humanoid (Any Race), Any Alignment

Armor Class 10
Hit Points 4 (1d8)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Senses Passive Perception 10
Languages Any one language (usually Common)
Challenge 0 (10 XP) **Proficiency Bonus** +2

Actions

Club. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 2 (1d4) bludgeoning damage.

Shadow

Medium Undead, Chaotic Evil

Armor Class 12
Hit Points 16 (3d8+3)
Speed 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
6 (-2)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	6 (-2)	10 (+0)	8 (-1)

Skills Stealth +4
Damage Vulnerabilities Radiant
Damage Resistances Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, Thunder; Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing from Nonmagical Attacks
Damage Immunities Necrotic, Poison
Condition Immunities Exhaustion, Frightened, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned, Prone, Restrained
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 10
Languages -
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP) **Proficiency Bonus** +2

Traits

Amorphous. The shadow can move through a space as narrow as 1 inch wide without squeezing.

Shadow Stealth. While in dim light or darkness, the shadow can take the Hide action as a bonus action.

Sunlight Weakness. While in sunlight, the shadow has disadvantage on attack rolls, ability checks, and saving throws.

Actions

Strength Drain. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 9 (2d6+2) necrotic damage, and the target's Strength score is reduced by 1d4. The target dies if this reduces its Strength to 0. Otherwise, the reduction lasts until the target finishes a short or long rest.

If a non-evil humanoid dies from this attack, a new shadow rises from the corpse 1d4 hours later.